

looking to turn a difficult financial situation around, not all of my motivation for budgeting came from a good place – as well as looking to make changes in how I was managing my money, I was also, I think, looking for a way to punish myself for my past mistakes. I hadn't completed the first couple of steps in this process at that point – in fact, I hadn't even really considered that there was more to do than fix the superficial elements of my finances. This was not really the right approach, and I made a lot of mistakes in those early days, being super-restrictive and setting unrealistic goals that made me feel like I was failing.

The issue was that my budgeting technique was, essentially, coming from a place of self-loathing. I hadn't made peace with my mistakes, and every ounce of my self-worth was tied to the £27,000-ish of personal debt that I'd accrued. There was a punitive aspect to it, which we commonly see in diet culture, an aspect of 'making up for' something. Before we get into the more practical elements of budgeting, which is really very simple, I'd like you to ask yourself: what are you trying to make up for? Are you going into this from a place of kindness towards yourself? Hopefully, after the first two steps, you are starting to better understand your relationship with money, and are working towards a more compassionate approach to your financial past and self-worth. You should also now have a better idea of *why* you want to make these changes, beyond just having more money, which will help you when shaping your budget.